01 Organization and policy scope

Purpose and status

Cedarbridge Studio is a fictional design and software company based in Lagos. This handbook is invented specifically for testing document retrieval and conversational memory. It is not a statement of Nigerian law or real employment advice. All policies, names, amounts, and contact addresses are fictional. Handbook version 1.0 is effective January 1, 2027.

Who this handbook covers

Unless a section specifies otherwise, these policies cover full-time employees after their start date. Interns receive the equipment and security protections described here, but their leave and learning benefits are defined in their internship agreements. Contractors follow their contracts for work hours, leave, and payment. A chatbot should not assume that a contractor receives full-time employee benefits.

Hours and communication

The normal workweek is Monday through Friday, 9:00 a.m. to 5:00 p.m., with a one-hour lunch break. Core collaboration hours are 10:00 a.m. to 3:00 p.m. Employees keep calendars up to date and tell their manager about planned absences. Client support operates from 8:00 a.m. to 6:00 p.m. on weekdays through a scheduled rota; this does not change every employee's standard hours.

Policy ownership

People Operations owns leave, onboarding, and performance policies. Finance owns reimbursement and travel procedures. IT owns device security and access. A line manager approves scheduling and routine purchases within the limits stated in each section. Approval from one team does not replace another approval explicitly required by a policy.

Contacts

People Operations can be reached at people@cedarbridge.example. Finance uses finance@cedarbridge.example. The IT help desk uses helpdesk@cedarbridge.example. Security incidents go to security@cedarbridge.example. The .example addresses are reserved fictional addresses and are not operational mailboxes.

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02 Leave and absence

Annual leave entitlement

Full-time employees receive 20 working days of paid annual leave per calendar year. Employees who join during the year receive a prorated allocation, rounded up to the next whole working day. A request must be submitted in the People Portal at least 14 calendar days before the first leave day. The line manager checks team coverage and approves or declines the requested dates within five working days.

Carry-over and expiry

Employees may carry over up to five unused annual leave days into the following calendar year. These carried-over annual leave days expire on March 31 of that following year. The People Portal uses carried-over days before using the new year's allocation. The five-day limit applies to annual leave only; it does not create a carry-over entitlement for sick leave or learning funds.

Worked example

If an employee has eight unused annual leave days on December 31, only five may be carried over. The other three lapse. If the employee takes two working days of annual leave in February, those two days are deducted from the carried-over balance first. Three carried-over days remain and must be used by March 31. This example assumes the employee had no other leave transactions.

Sick leave

Full-time employees receive 10 paid sick days per calendar year. Sick leave does not carry over. Notify the manager as soon as practical, preferably before core hours start. A medical note is requested when an absence exceeds three consecutive working days. Employees should not disclose a diagnosis to teammates; People Operations handles necessary supporting documents privately.

Other absences

Bereavement leave provides up to three paid working days for the death of an immediate family member. Unpaid leave of up to 10 working days may be approved by the manager and People Operations together. Unpaid leave requests should be made 21 calendar days in advance when possible. Public holidays published in the company calendar are separate from annual leave.

Changing a leave booking

To cancel approved annual leave, update the People Portal before the first booked day and notify the manager. A reschedule requires a new approval because team coverage may have changed. An employee returning earlier than planned should contact People Operations to correct the leave balance. A carried-over day cannot be used after March 31 merely because it was booked before that date.

03 Remote work and office routines

Standard hybrid arrangement

Employees may work remotely up to three days per week with line manager approval. Tuesday is the shared office day for team meetings. The default arrangement is three remote days and two office days, with the second office day agreed within the team. Remote days are not an additional leave entitlement; normal working hours and availability still apply.

Planning a remote day

Set the work location in the calendar by 4:00 p.m. on the previous working day. Remain reachable during core hours, 10:00 a.m. to 3:00 p.m., and attend scheduled calls. Employees may take breaks but should update their status if they will be unavailable for more than 30 minutes during core hours. Managers evaluate deliverables and collaboration rather than continuous online activity.

Fully remote exceptions

A fully remote arrangement requires written approval from both the line manager and People Operations. The approval records the location, start date, review date, and office attendance expectations. It is reviewed every three months. A fully remote exception can change Tuesday attendance expectations only if the written approval explicitly says so; ordinary remote approval does not waive Tuesday attendance.

Connectivity and support

After probation, eligible employees may claim up to NGN 15,000 per month for home internet service used for work. Submit an itemized invoice through the expense process. This allowance is a monthly reimbursement cap, not an automatic cash payment. Unclaimed internet allowance does not roll over. Managers may arrange office work if connectivity prevents effective remote work.

Workspace and confidentiality

Use a stable internet connection and a private location for client calls. Lock the screen when leaving a device unattended. Do not work with confidential client material on public computers. Company laptops must use the company VPN when accessing restricted internal systems from outside the office. A personal device is not approved merely because it has a VPN installed.

Visitors and office access

Office access is available from 8:00 a.m. to 7:00 p.m. on working days. Visitors sign in at reception and must be accompanied by an employee beyond the meeting area. After-hours access requires Facilities approval at least one working day in advance. An approved expense or travel booking does not automatically approve after-hours office access.

04 Expenses and reimbursement

Submission deadline

Submit work-related expense claims within 30 calendar days of purchase. Every claim includes an itemized receipt, a business purpose, and a project code when the expense relates to a client project. The receipt date determines the deadline, not the date of manager approval. Keep the original receipt until the claim is closed.

Approval amounts

For a single claim of NGN 50,000 or less, the line manager approves the business purpose and Finance checks the documentation. A claim above NGN 50,000 also requires department head approval. Split purchases made for the same purpose on the same day are treated as one claim for this approval threshold. At exactly NGN 50,000, additional department head approval is not required.

Missing receipts

If a receipt is lost, submit a missing-receipt declaration within the normal 30-day window. A bank transaction record alone does not replace the declaration. Finance may accept declarations for claims up to NGN 10,000 after manager approval. Claims above NGN 10,000 require Finance to review alternative supporting evidence before any reimbursement is promised.

Payment timing

Claims fully approved by the 20th calendar day of the month are normally reimbursed in that month's payroll. Claims approved after the 20th are normally paid in the next month's payroll. A submitted claim is not necessarily fully approved. An incomplete claim is returned for correction, and payment timing follows the date of final approval.

Eligible and ineligible costs

Eligible costs include approved business transport, approved training, and necessary client project materials. Alcohol, personal entertainment, parking penalties, and upgrades bought for personal preference are not reimbursable. A manager cannot override an explicit exclusion by approving the business purpose. Questions about a cost not listed here should be escalated to Finance rather than assumed eligible.

Example

A NGN 65,000 approved training purchase needs the line manager, department head, and Finance checks described above. If final approval is completed on April 22, reimbursement normally occurs in May payroll. Learning budget approval is also required before purchase under page 5; the expense approvals do not retrospectively replace that pre-purchase approval.

05 Learning and development

Annual budget

Each full-time employee who has completed probation has an annual learning budget of NGN 300,000 for relevant courses, books, and conferences. The learning budget does not roll over to the next calendar year. It is a spending limit, not a payment automatically added to salary. People Operations tracks the remaining balance in the Learning Register.

Request and approval

Before buying a learning activity, send the manager its title, provider, price, intended skills, and expected time commitment. The manager approves relevance, and People Operations confirms eligibility and the remaining budget. Both confirmations are required before purchase. Reimbursement then follows the documentation and approval rules on page 4.

Budget example

If an eligible employee spends NGN 120,000 on an approved course, NGN 180,000 remains from the NGN 300,000 annual learning budget, assuming no other purchases. If the employee does not use the remaining balance by December 31, it expires. This expiry differs from annual leave carry-over, which can last until March 31.

Learning time

Employees may use up to two paid working days per calendar year for approved learning activities. These days require manager scheduling approval, are separate from annual leave, and do not carry over. Additional learning time can be taken as approved annual leave or agreed outside work hours. Course price approval does not automatically approve time away from regular duties.

Sharing what was learned

Within 14 calendar days of completing a funded course or conference, post a short learning note in the team knowledge base. The note includes three practical takeaways and one suggested application to current work. A certificate is useful where available, but the learning note is still required if the provider does not issue certificates.

Cancellations and limits

If a provider cancels a course and returns the full fee, Finance restores the reimbursed amount to the employee's learning balance for the same year. A credit valid next year does not automatically create next-year budget carry-over. Partial refunds restore only the returned amount. This handbook does not promise funding above NGN 300,000; requests above that limit require a separate decision not specified here.

06 Equipment, access and security

Company equipment

The company supplies a laptop, charger, and approved software accounts. An external monitor may be requested for the office or home workspace with manager approval. IT records the equipment serial numbers. Company devices remain company property and must be returned when employment ends. Personal devices may not access restricted client repositories without explicit IT authorization.

Lost or stolen laptop

Contact the IT help desk immediately at helpdesk@cedarbridge.example and notify the line manager. Include the device name, approximate loss time, last known location, and whether the device was unlocked. IT remotely locks the device and coordinates a replacement. If client data may have been exposed, also notify security@cedarbridge.example. Do not wait until the next working day to report a lost laptop.

Replacement timing

IT targets a temporary replacement laptop within two working days after the lost-device report is logged, subject to stock availability. A temporary replacement does not close the security investigation. The employee should follow IT instructions about account access and password changes before resuming restricted work. The handbook gives no fixed date for delivery of a permanent replacement.

Passwords and account access

Use the approved password manager and multi-factor authentication for company accounts. Do not share passwords or verification codes. If an employee suspects account compromise, notify IT immediately and follow the incident instructions. A manager should request access for a new team member through the Access Portal; credentials must never be copied from another employee.

Phishing and suspicious messages

Do not open unexpected attachments or follow suspicious login links. Report suspected phishing through the email client's Report Phishing function. If a link has already been clicked or credentials entered, also contact IT and Security immediately. Do not assume deleting the message resolves the incident.

Data handling

Client confidential files belong in approved project storage, not personal email or public file-sharing links. When sharing externally, the project owner confirms the recipients and minimum required access. IT reviews access every quarter. The normal access-removal target for a departing employee is by the end of their final working day, coordinated by People Operations and IT.

07 Onboarding and performance

First week

People Operations sends the onboarding checklist before the employee's first day. On day one, IT sets up the laptop, multi-factor authentication, and basic accounts. The manager explains role expectations and assigns an onboarding buddy. By the end of week one, the employee completes security training and confirms emergency contact information in the People Portal.

Probation

The standard probation period is three calendar months. The manager holds a progress conversation at the end of each month. Completion is confirmed in writing by People Operations after manager review. The manager may recommend an extension, but the extension length and conditions require a separate written agreement; this handbook does not specify an automatic extension period.

Benefits after probation

Learning budget eligibility and the home internet allowance begin after written confirmation of probation completion. Annual leave and paid sick leave apply from the start date under page 2 and are not delayed until probation ends. A new employee should not assume that every benefit begins at the same time.

Review cycle

Formal performance reviews take place twice each year, in June and December. Employees complete a self-review at least seven calendar days before the review meeting. Managers discuss delivery, collaboration, growth, and support needs. The review meeting produces written goals and follow-up actions, which both parties can access.

Ongoing feedback

Managers schedule a one-to-one conversation every two weeks. A one-to-one can cover priorities, blockers, wellbeing, and development. Employees can request an additional conversation when an issue is urgent. Formal June and December reviews do not replace these regular check-ins.

Concerns and confidentiality

Raise routine work concerns with the manager first where appropriate. If the concern involves the manager or cannot be resolved, contact People Operations. People Operations records the concern and agrees on a follow-up date. The handbook promises a respectful process but does not prescribe a fixed resolution deadline for every complaint. It does not define salary increases, bonus rates, or promotion quotas.

08 Project delivery and business travel

Project roles

Each client project has a project owner, a delivery lead, and a reviewer. The project owner confirms scope and client approval. The delivery lead coordinates milestones and dependencies. The reviewer checks quality before release. One person may hold more than one role, but the release review must be completed by someone other than the author of the deliverable.

Milestones and status

The delivery lead posts a weekly project update by Friday at 3:00 p.m. The update lists completed work, next steps, risks, and decisions needed. A milestone expected to slip by more than two working days must be escalated to the project owner as soon as the risk is known. Waiting for the Friday update is not appropriate for a time-sensitive delay.

Scope changes

A new client request that changes cost, timeline, or acceptance criteria must be recorded in the Change Log. The project owner obtains written client agreement before the team commits to the revised scope. An informal chat with a client is not a substitute for recorded approval. The delivery lead updates the schedule after approval.

Travel pre-approval

Business travel requires manager approval and Finance confirmation of the estimated cost before bookings are made. Submit the travel request at least 10 calendar days before departure where possible. Urgent travel can be reviewed sooner, but urgency does not remove the approval requirement. Use the company booking process rather than personal bookings unless Finance authorizes an exception.

Travel costs

The domestic accommodation cap is NGN 80,000 per night, including mandatory taxes and fees. A higher rate requires department head approval before booking. Meal reimbursement on approved domestic travel is capped at NGN 12,000 per day and requires receipts. These are caps on reimbursement, not automatic allowances. Claims still follow the 30-calendar-day expense submission rule on page 4.

Worked travel example

A two-night domestic trip with a hotel at NGN 75,000 per night is within the nightly accommodation cap. The total hotel charge of NGN 150,000 is above the NGN 50,000 claim threshold and therefore also needs department head approval during expense processing. Being within a nightly cap does not remove the separate claim-value approval rule. Submit receipts within 30 calendar days of purchase; final approval by the 20th normally allows payment in the same month's payroll.